THE CURIOSITY SERIES · ARTICLE IV

Wordsmiths in the Dark

What the "godmother of AI" really said about language models — and the data.

Akshat Verma

Language models · spatial intelligence · world models

THE CURIOSITY SERIES · FACT-CHECK № 04 · filed by Akshat Verma



Fei-Fei Li

the "godmother of AI"

Photo: ITU event · credit ITU

CASE SUMMARY

A viral 7-slide carousel claims Fei-Fei Li — the researcher who built ImageNet and helped launch the deep-learning era — declared large language models *dead*. She did not. This dossier lays out what she actually argued, the data behind it, and the one line the card quietly erased.

INSIDE THIS DOSSIER

① The Claim · ② The Source · ③ The Evidence · ④ The Frontier · ⑤ The Catch · ⑥ The Verdict

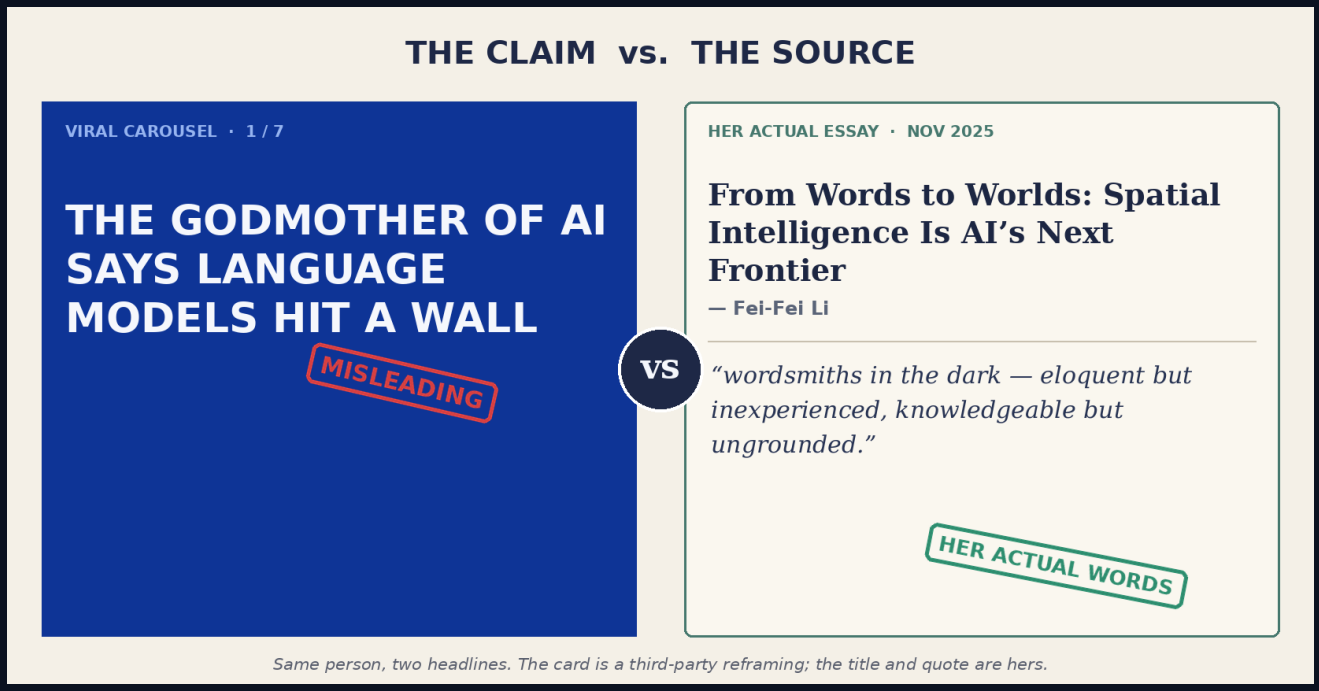
BY THE NUMBERS

79%
humans on VSI-Bench, the 3D-space test

~46%
the best AI model on the same test

71%
of AI errors are spatial-reasoning failures

① THE CLAIM

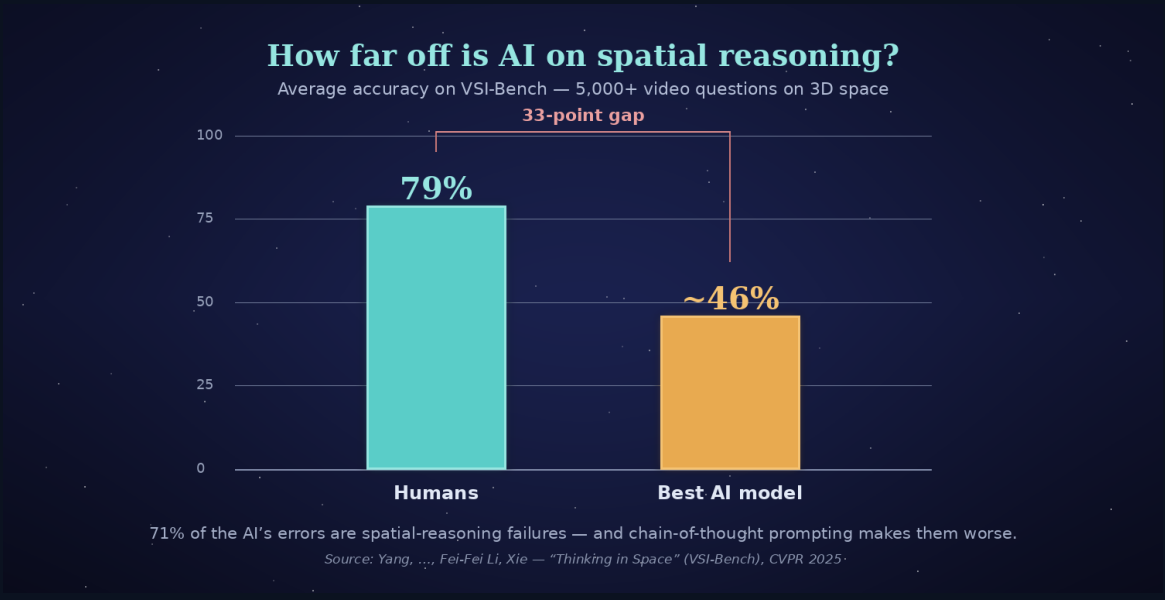


Two headlines, one person. Only one of them is hers.

② THE SOURCE

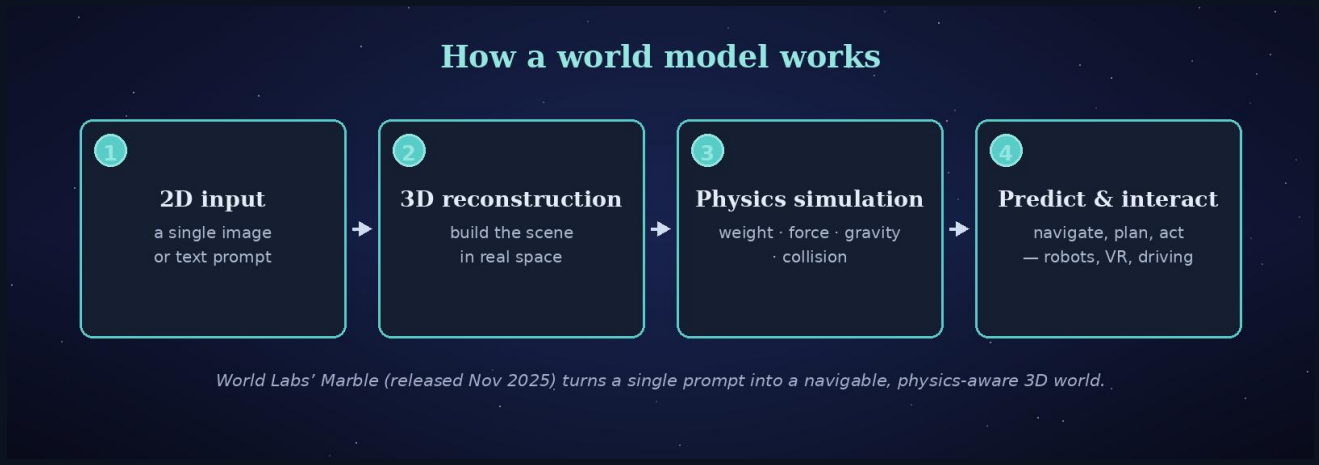
Her point is about a limit, not a death. Language lets a model *talk about* the world; it does not let the model understand one or act in it. The next frontier, she argues, is **spatial intelligence** — "the scaffolding upon which our cognition is built" — and the tool for it is a **world model** that reasons in three dimensions, not just in text. In her words, language models remain "wordsmiths in the dark" — fluent about a world they have never touched.

③ THE EVIDENCE



The gap is not rhetorical; it is measured. On VSI-Bench, a 5,000-question spatial test built by Li's own team, humans score 79% and the best model about 46%. And the models do not fail because they cannot see — 71% of their errors are failures of spatial *reasoning*, not perception.

④ THE FRONTIER



World Labs' Marble (released Nov 2025) turns a single prompt into a navigable, physics-aware 3D world.

A world model closes that gap by doing what language cannot: turning a flat image into a navigable, physics-aware space. Li's company, World Labs, shipped exactly this in November 2025 with Marble — a system that builds a 3D world you can walk through from a single prompt. It is the same bet she made with ImageNet: give AI the missing ingredient — then, data; now, space — and let capability follow.

⑤ THE CATCH

What the card erases. Li is not predicting the end of language models. She frames spatial intelligence as a *complement* to them, on a decade-long curve — not a replacement arriving next year. A legal analysis of this very claim concluded it is "premature to predict the demise of LLMs," and across the industry the models keep improving. "Hit a wall" is the carousel's phrase, not hers.

⑥ THE VERDICT

The real eye-opener isn't "LLMs are dead." It is that one of the most cited scientists in AI just told you exactly where today's models are blind — and put a number on it. "Wordsmiths in the dark" is a diagnosis, not an obituary.

Sources: Fei-Fei Li, "From Words to Worlds: Spatial Intelligence Is AI's Next Frontier" (Substack / TIME, Nov 2025) and interviews (TIME, 2025–26). Data — Yang, Yang, Gupta, Han, Fei-Fei Li & Xie, "Thinking in Space" (VSI-Bench), CVPR 2025: humans 79% vs best model ~46%, 71% of errors from spatial reasoning. World Labs' Marble released Nov 2025. Counterpoint — "Have large language models hit a wall?" (Lexology, Nov 2025); TIME (Apr 2026). The "hit a wall" headline is a third-party framing, not Li's wording. Portrait: ITU event photo supplied by the author — credit ITU and confirm licence (ITU event imagery is commonly CC-licensed) before publishing.

Next — Fact-Check Nº 05. Seen a viral AI claim worth checking? Send it to me.